WORLD_BUILDERS_GUIDE

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Loner 4e: World Builder's Guide

Introduction

Loner invites you to tell stories in worlds of your own design, whether you start from something familiar or invent from nothing. This guide is the toolset: how to build a setting, populate it with people and places, and keep it reacting to a protagonist who plays alone.

The chapters cover:

- **Develop a Setting** – tone, conflict, and genre, built loosely enough to survive contact with play.
- **Create Character Archetypes** – protagonists, antagonists, and allies whose motivations come from the setting itself.
- **Build Locations & Story Hooks** – places with a history, a tension, and a reason to matter.
- **Adapt Existing Settings** – carry a published world or a favorite universe over without its group-based assumptions.
- **Make It All Interactive** – connect the pieces so the world moves on its own, not just when the protagonist is looking.

Who This Guide is For

New and experienced worldbuilders alike. What it assumes is that the setting isn't fixed at the start: it grows and shifts

as the Oracle answers questions you didn't know you were asking.

Building Your Setting

A setting shapes the challenges your Protagonist encounters, the tone of the story, and the themes that surface through play. This section is about building one that stays reactive once play begins, not one you finish before the first scene.

The Core of a Setting

Your setting decides what your Protagonist can choose, what stands in their way, and where the fiction is likely to go.

1. Theme & Genre

Theme and genre set the rules of the world before a single scene opens: what the story expects, what it looks like, what kinds of challenges belong in it.

- **What defines this world?** Grounded in realism, or built on the impossible? Ancient mysticism, cutting-edge technology, or both at once? Start broad, *a flooded world where the last cities float above the waves*, and refine from there.

- **What genre does it fall into?** High fantasy, cyberpunk, cosmic horror, post-apocalypse, space opera, or a genre blend: *steampunk eldritch horror*, *western noir*, *solarpunk detective fiction*.
- **How do genre conventions shape the story?** A *dark fantasy* setting runs grim and costly; magic exacts a price. A *hopepunk* setting centers resilience and communities resisting oppression. The genre decides what kind of victories and defeats belong to your protagonist.
- **Does it embrace or subvert tropes?** Heroic knights and tyrannical sorcerers is the expected shape. Corrupt knights and sorcerers who are the last defenders of justice is the same shape, inverted, and inversion is where a setting starts to feel like yours.

📌 **Example: Theme & Genre in Action**

Cyberpunk: *A cyberpunk city under a perpetual storm, where neon-lit corporations wage shadow wars for control over underground data caches. The rich live above the clouds in floating enclaves, while the streets below are ruled by rogue AIs and data smugglers. The genre leans into cyberpunk, but with a supernatural twist: ghosts exist within the network, and forgotten souls haunt corrupted servers.*

Medieval Fantasy: *A world where ancient kingdoms clash over divine relics, and magic is feared as much as it is revered. The protagonist is a disgraced knight seeking redemption, moving through a land torn between prophecy and political intrigue. In Loner, this setting could emphasize honor-bound duels, factional disputes,*

and moral dilemmas, where every decision shifts the balance of power.

Hard Sci-Fi: *On a remote colony at the edge of explored space, corporate powers strip the land for profit while rogue scientists stumble upon reality-warping phenomena. The Protagonist, a former researcher turned fugitive, carries knowledge too dangerous to share and too costly to bury. This setting thrives on scarcity, tension, and survival, where every decision edges closer to revelation or oblivion.*

2. A Central Conflict

No world is static. Even the most peaceful setting has an undercurrent of movement, and naming its central conflict is what decides which challenges your protagonist will actually face.

- **What is the world's core struggle?** A war, an oppressive government, a resource crisis, an ancient prophecy slowly unraveling, whatever it is, it should press on the world even before the protagonist notices it.
- **How visible is the conflict?** Open war and societal collapse announce themselves. Whispers of rebellion, an unexplained sickness, a cosmic force altering reality unnoticed, don't. Decide whether your setting runs on subtle, creeping dread or conflict in the foreground; the two produce very different stories.
- **How does this conflict shape daily life?** A war everyone talks about feels different from a threat only a few understand is waking after centuries of peace. Does it force people to take sides, or let most of them look away?

- **How does it impact the protagonist?** They don't have to recognize it yet, but the conflict has to bear on them: caught in the middle, or an outsider looking in; fighting for survival, for justice, or just trying to understand the world they're standing in.

📌 **Example: Central Conflict in Action**

> The city was built around a rift in reality, a wound in space-time that leaks fragments of alternate dimensions. The government insists it can be contained, but the lower districts have begun to twist, architecture warping overnight, people waking up with memories of lives they never lived. An underground faction believes the rift is alive: that it is learning, that it is watching. The protagonist? A courier hired to deliver a package that should not exist, one that whispers in their hands.

3. Tone & Mood

Tone and mood decide how the world feels: how challenges get presented, how NPCs behave, what the story's emotional weight is made of.

- **What kind of atmosphere does this world evoke?** Full of wonder, like a realm teeming with adventure, or tense and suffocating, like a society on the verge of collapse. Flourishing, in decay, or balanced precariously before a shift, each carries a different weight.
- **What emotions should the story evoke?** Awe and curiosity, tension and unease, urgency and exhilaration. A derelict station echoing with secrets and a society on the brink of revolt can both work, but they aren't the same story.

- **Does the world encourage hope or despair?** Some settings can still be saved: people fight back, there's light at the end. Others run on inevitable entropy: civilization crumbling, the gods already dead, survival as long as possible the only goal left.
- **How does the mood shape the way stories unfold?** A lighthearted, swashbuckling setting produces rooftop escapes. A cold, post-apocalyptic one produces people huddled in the dark, rationing what's left. Same structure, opposite texture.

📌 **Example: Tone & Mood in Action**

> A city that never sleeps, where neon lights flicker in endless rain, where androids and humans fight for a place in a world that sees them as disposable. The tone is bleak and melancholic; hope exists, but it is small, fragile, and easily lost. Trust is currency, and betrayal is inevitable.

4. The Role of Your Protagonist

The Protagonist is the lens for the whole setting: where they stand in it decides which conflicts reach them and how they approach an obstacle.

- **What kinds of people exist in this world?** Warriors and sorcerers, smugglers and rebels, explorers and scientists, and which of them rise to prominence versus which get cast aside.
- **Is the protagonist part of the world or an outsider?** A renegade breaking free of a corrupt society and a scholar uncovering lost knowledge occupy the same setting very differently.

- **Are they an agent of change or a reluctant participant?** A revolutionary drives the story forward; a refugee reacts to what the story does to them. Both are valid, but they aren't the same protagonist.

📌 **Example: The Protagonist's Role in Action**

> In a drowned world where the last cities float above the endless ocean, the Protagonist is a salvager, a diver who retrieves artifacts from the sunken past. Some believe they're searching for treasure. In truth, they're looking for something else: evidence that the world before the flood can still be saved.

Making the Setting Playable

In *Loner*, build the setting in broad strokes rather than a complete world before play begins. The more room you leave for discovery, the more the story grows organically.

1. Build Broad Strokes, Not a Blueprint

The biggest pitfall in worldbuilding is over-preparing: detailing every city, history, and minor political conflict before play even starts. Sketch the major elements, theme, conflict, mood, the Protagonist's place, and let the rest emerge.

- **Leave gaps for discovery.** Define one or two kingdoms, not the whole map; one pivotal event, not a full timeline. The rest takes shape when the story demands it.
- **Define what makes the world unique.** How does the magic work, or what's the tech level, or what are the rules of the unknown? A few core principles do more work than pages of lore.

- **Start with a mystery, not an answer.** A lost civilization, a missing colony ship, a prophecy no one believes anymore, something even the world's own inhabitants don't fully understand is what gives the story room to grow.

📌 **Example: Loose Worldbuilding in Action**

> Instead of creating a complete political history of an empire, define a single event:
>
> "The sky broke open a century ago, and something fell through. No one knows what it was, but it changed the land forever."

2. Make the World Reactive

The world shouldn't wait for the protagonist to move: factions pursue goals whether or not anyone's watching, environments change, old forces wake up. Build in at least three pressure points already in motion before the story opens.

- **Factions should have agendas.** Don't just describe a faction's history; define what they want and what they'll do to get it. A secretive mage cabal is more interesting the moment you know they've just lost their most dangerous artifact and will stop at nothing to retrieve it.
- **Actions should have consequences.** A dead crime lord leaves a power vacuum. An exposed secret gets noticed. Let the world respond instead of resetting.
- **Nothing is static.** An abandoned city can be in the process of being reclaimed. A planet thought lifeless can start showing signs of activity.

📌 **Example: A Reactive World in Action**

> The protagonist steals a relic from an abandoned monastery. Unknown to them, this relic was keeping an ancient force dormant. Days later, whispers of strange occurrences begin: people disappearing, shadows moving unnaturally. The world is no longer the same because of their actions.

3. Let the World Generate Storylines

A well-designed setting creates stories on its own. Define forces at work, tensions that can shift, and unknowns waiting to surface, instead of planning a single narrative path.

- **What power struggles exist?** Factions on the brink of war, old rulers being replaced, someone gaining influence at someone else's expense.
- **What is being uncovered?** A rediscovered civilization, resurfacing forbidden technology, a mystery finally cracking open.
- **What is changing?** Magic returning after centuries of dormancy, an empire crumbling, an apocalypse unfolding in slow motion.

📌 **Example: A World That Generates Stories**

> A city has stood untouched for centuries, hidden by an unknown force. Suddenly, for reasons no one understands, its gates have opened.

If a world-level pressure spans multiple sessions, a faction closing in, a disaster unfolding in slow motion, the 4th Edition core rules include a **Challenge Track**: a four-box

progress record for arcs too large to resolve in a single oracle roll. Open one for the world-level force, not just the Protagonist's goal.

4. Blend Genres to Break Expectations

Once the core elements are in place, mixing genres can push a setting somewhere harder to categorize, and harder to predict.

- **What core elements define each genre?** Know what makes a *western* a western, or *horror* unsettling, before you blend it with something else. The hybrid holds together only if both halves are understood, not just aesthetically borrowed.
- **How do genres complement or contrast?** *Steampunk noir* reinforces itself: technology deepens the mystery and corruption already native to noir. *Horror western* has to be balanced instead: let the supernatural amplify the frontier's tension rather than swallow it.
- **How does the protagonist fit into this hybrid world?** A *horror western* gunslinger who unknowingly hunts something beyond human understanding and a *steampunk noir* detective navigating industrial smog and conspiracy are both shaped by the genre mix they inhabit, not dropped into it after the fact.

📌 **Example: Blending Genres in Action**

> The frontier town of Black Hollow stands alone in the wastelands, where the sky burns red at dusk and the wind carries whispers from the mines below. The Protagonist, a bounty hunter wielding a cursed six-shooter, tracks outlaws through desolate canyons, only to realize their targets may not be human at all. Legends speak

of an ancient hunger beneath the sands, and surviving this place means understanding a world that defies both mortal law and natural order.

5. Pace What the World Reveals

A setting that shows everything at once has no mystery. A setting that withholds everything frustrates. Structure your world's information in layers:

- **Visible on arrival.** What the protagonist can see and hear in their first scene: the faction flags on the walls, the armed guards, the smell of burning. This is immediate context, not backstory.
- **Available through investigation.** What a question, a bribe, or a roll reveals: who controls the district, what happened last month, which NPC has a reason to help. This is the layer the Oracle populates.
- **Discovered through consequence.** What only becomes clear after the protagonist has acted: the true nature of the organization they joined, the identity of the force they disturbed, the cost of the choice they made three sessions ago. Reserve these for when the story has earned them.

The Oracle drives all three layers. Start a session with the visible layer in place and let play determine what the other two reveal.

Integrating Mechanics with Worldbuilding

The Oracle doesn't only answer questions about the protagonist. It can drive faction behavior, environmental changes, and story-level pressures. The mechanic that resolves "Does the protagonist succeed?" works equally well for "Has the rebellion grown strong enough to challenge the council?" This section shows how.

1. Using the Oracle to Drive World Events

The Oracle isn't just for Protagonist actions; it can shape the world directly. Use it to introduce consequences, faction shifts, and environmental changes you didn't plan in advance.

- **Faction Power Dynamics**: When a faction gains or loses influence, let the Oracle decide:
  - *"Has the ruling council lost control over the city?"* → If the answer is *Yes, and...*, perhaps a rival faction moves in, changing the landscape.
  - *"Does the underground rebellion successfully disrupt the government?"* → If the answer is *No, but...*, maybe they fail, but new splinter groups emerge, creating tension.
- **Environmental Shifts**: Settings should be **active and reactive**. Instead of setting world events in stone, introduce rolling uncertainty:
  - *"Has the wasteland storm reached the city?"* → A *Yes, and...* result might mean the settlement is now cut off from the outside world.
  - *"Is the ancient temple still standing after the last earthquake?"* → A *No, and...* means it has collapsed, but perhaps revealing new ruins below.

2. Tying Setting Creation to Mechanics

Every setting choice should carry through into character creation, exploration, and progression.

- **Tags as Setting Elements**:
  - Tags are Loner's qualitative descriptors: short phrases that replace numerical stats and define what a character, faction, or location can do and how they behave in the fiction. Locations, factions, and objects should have **tags** that define how they interact with the protagonist.
  - Example: A **Drowned World** setting might introduce *"Submerged Ruins" (treacherous footing, hidden artifacts)* or *"Survivor Enclaves" (secretive, resource-starved groups)*.
  - The Oracle can determine if these **tags** create advantages or obstacles in gameplay.
- **Setting-Based Challenges**:
  - Instead of generic skill checks, ensure challenges reflect the world's unique aspects.
  - *Example: In a city built on floating platforms, every chase sequence involves unstable terrain and vertigo-inducing jumps*.
  - The **Oracle** can introduce **new complications**.

📌 **Example: Setting Mechanics in Three Genres**

Fantasy Noir. The city's noble houses and criminal underworld struggle for dominance. Oracle question: *"Does House Verdan suspect the Protagonist's investigation?"* Result: **Yes, but...** They suspect someone, but blame a rival faction instead.

Post-Apocalyptic Wasteland. Radiation storms force settlements to relocate. Oracle question: *"Has the storm made the highway impassable?"* Result: **No, but...** The storm has weakened the bridges, making travel dangerous.

Hard Sci-Fi Colony. Corporate control versus local rebellion. Oracle question: *"Has the resistance intercepted corporate communications?"* Result: **Yes, and...** They find a hidden distress signal, complicating alliances.

Character Archetypes & NPCs

Every character should emerge from the world itself: rooted in its conflicts, culture, and history, whether they're a revolutionary, a drifter, or an exile.

Designing Protagonists for the Setting

A Protagonist is shaped by the world they come from, not dropped into it as a stateless figure. The best ones feel like they couldn't exist anywhere else, because their struggles and flaws come directly from the setting around them.

- **What kind of people thrive (or struggle) in this world?** A world where warriors rule and scholars are forgotten produces a different protagonist than one where knowledge is power and might alone means nothing. Fit the role to the setting's actual power dynamics.
- **Are they an outcast or an insider?** Some protagonists challenge the norms of their world outright. Others are entrenched in it and only starting to question their place.

- **What kind of tension exists in their role?** Full alignment with the world gives a protagonist little to push against. Tension comes from standing on the brink of something greater: a revelation about to surface, a rebellion gaining ground, a narrow window before it closes.

📌 **Example: A Protagonist Shaped by the World**

> In a world where gods walk among mortals, the protagonist is an exile from a theocratic city-state, branded a heretic for questioning divine law. They know the gods are not what they seem, but proving it means being hunted by the very faith they once served.

Building a Strong Character Framework

A *Loner* protagonist is built from a few elements. None are stats; all are narrative tools that decide how the character engages with the world and what drives them through it.

1. Concept: The Core of the Character

A strong concept distills the protagonist into a single evocative phrase, and it's the first thing that defines how they meet the world.

- **Avoid generic labels.** "Mercenary" is a job description. "Disillusioned War Veteran" or "Debt-Ridden Blade for Hire" is a person.
- **Make it immediately suggestive.** The phrase should hint at personality, history, or conflict on its own, without further explanation.
- **Keep it compact.** Short and memorable is what sparks a story idea on first read.

📌 **Example: Strong Character Concepts**

- *Haunted Relic Hunter*: implies a past mistake, supernatural dangers, and obsession.
- *Loyal Spy in Enemy Territory*: suggests conflict, intrigue, and betrayal.
- *Exiled Warlock Seeking Redemption*: a fall from grace, a quest for atonement, and dangerous magic.

2. Skills & Weaknesses: Strengths That Shape Play

Skills aren't numerical bonuses; they're permission to attempt something the fiction supports. A weakness isn't just a drawback; it's where the drama actually comes from.

- **Pick two defining skills.** They should say something about how this character specifically solves problems, not just that they're competent.
- **Choose one frailty.** A flaw, limitation, or belief that creates complications when it matters most.

📌 **Example: Skills & Weaknesses in Action**

Sarai, a Fallen Knight

- **Skills:** *Blademaster* (Unmatched with a sword), *Fearless* (Does not hesitate in battle)
- **Weakness:** *Bound by Honor* (Cannot break an oath, even when it works against her)

3. Motive & Goal: Why They Keep Moving

A goal isn't static; it shifts as the story develops. Without one, a protagonist is a bystander in their own world.

- **Motive:** The personal drive underneath the action, revenge, redemption, a desperate search for answers.

- **Goal:** What they're actively trying to achieve, specific enough that they can actually succeed or fail at it.

📌 **Example: A Goal That Evolves**

A fugitive scientist's goal begins as "escape the corporate agents hunting them." But after discovering classified data, their goal shifts to "expose the conspiracy before they're silenced."

4. Nemesis: What Stands in Their Way

A nemesis doesn't have to be a person. An organization, an ideology, the world itself, anything that challenges the protagonist's beliefs, strategies, or survival qualifies.

- **A nemesis should be personal.** Blocking the goal isn't enough; the best ones make it hurt: a former friend turned rival, a government that brands them a traitor, a past mistake that won't stop catching up.
- **A nemesis should challenge their beliefs.** An idealist protagonist against a hardened cynic. Someone seeking justice against a nemesis who reveals uncomfortable truths about power.
- **A nemesis can evolve.** A minor threat becomes a major adversary. A former ally becomes an enemy. A larger force shifts its focus and the protagonist becomes the target.

📌 **Example: Strong Nemeses**

- **The Faithful Hounds**: a religious order hunting the protagonist for blasphemy.
- **The Hollow King**: a tyrant who has ruled for centuries, who the protagonist was once loyal to.

- **The Dying Sun**: the world itself is collapsing, and nothing can stop it, only delay it.

The *Loner* core rules cover the full protagonist creation procedure, including how to select Skills, Frailties, and Gear that fit your specific setting. The framework above gives you narrative context; the core rules give you the mechanical steps, and the *Loner Companion* explores the judgment calls behind them.

Designing NPCs That Matter

Build a handful of characters who shape the story, not an exhaustive cast.

1. Prioritize Meaningful NPCs Over Background Noise

A shopkeeper who serves one function once doesn't need a backstory. Save the detail for characters who push the story forward.

The core rules give a practical threshold: something that matters once stays as plain tags; something that keeps showing up or pushes back earns a full character sheet. Build out only the NPCs who have already crossed that line, or who you expect will.

- **Who influences the protagonist's path?** NPCs who reveal information, block the way, or offer an alliance are worth the detail.
- **Who represents the world's tensions?** A corrupt official, a revolutionary, a scientist racing against time, each embodies a struggle the setting is already having.
- **Who brings personal stakes?** A long-lost friend, a former mentor, a bitter rival, an emotional tie is what makes their decisions land.

📌 **Example: A Focused Cast of NPCs**

In a cyberpunk dystopia, instead of detailing every corporate executive, you define:

- **Dr. Veylan** – A cybernetics researcher who holds the key to unlocking restricted technology.
- **Wren** – A street-level hacker with ties to an underground resistance.
- **Marshal Graves** – A bounty hunter tasked with eliminating "unregistered" individuals, including the protagonist.

2. Define NPCs Based on Their Relationship to the Protagonist

NPCs don't exist in a vacuum; they should **connect to the protagonist's goals and conflicts**. The best way to create an impactful NPC is to define **what they want** and **how that conflicts or aligns with the protagonist's goals**.

NPCs generally fall into four key roles:

Allies

- **What do they provide?** Do they offer resources, knowledge, or protection?
- **What do they expect in return?** Alliances carry a price; define what the ally wants before they're needed.

Example: *Selene, a smuggler who provides safe passage in exchange for favors she'll call in later.*

Rivals

- **Are they hostile or just opposition?** Not every rival is a villain; some might have conflicting but understandable goals.

- **Can they become allies?** A rival today might be an uneasy partner tomorrow.

Example: *Rylos, a rogue scavenger who always seems to be one step ahead in the hunt for lost artifacts.*

Informants

- **What do they know that the protagonist doesn't?**
- **Can they be trusted?** Some informants provide reliable intel, while others manipulate for their own ends.

Example: *Father Kain, a priest with ties to an underground network, who leaks valuable information, but always with a cryptic warning.*

Mentors

- **Do they still practice what they teach?** Some mentors are relics of another era, watching their lessons become obsolete.
- **What do they fear about their own legacy?** Mentors often worry about what their students will become.

Example: *Master Sothis, an old warrior who once fought for the empire but now trains rebels in secret.*

3. Keep NPC Descriptions Minimal but Impactful

An NPC doesn't need paragraphs of history. They need a defining trait, an agenda, and a connection to the protagonist.

A simple but effective format covers five elements:

- **Name**: A short, memorable name.
- **Concept**: A brief description of who they are.
- **Agenda**: What they want, and how that impacts the Protagonist.

- **Relationship**: How they view the Protagonist (ally, rival, neutral, manipulative, etc.).
- **Evolving Potential**: How they might change over time.

📌 **Example: Minimalist NPC Profiles**

Field	Ezran the Smiling Fox	Captain Reyna Doss
Concept	A corrupt bureaucrat who survives by playing all sides	An ex-military officer turned mercenary leader
Agenda	Wants to stay ahead of every power shift	Wants to reclaim her lost reputation through one final mission
Relationship	Sees the Protagonist as useful, for now	Views the Protagonist as a wildcard: an asset or a liability
Evolving Potential	If betrayed, becomes a dangerous enemy with political influence	Might become a reluctant ally if their goals align

This format works for NPCs who haven't yet crossed the Promotion Rule threshold. Once an NPC earns a full character sheet, the fields carry over directly: Concept stays as-is; Agenda becomes Goal and Motive (split into what they want and why they want it); Relationship becomes a relationship tag on the Protagonist's sheet rather than a description of the NPC's stance. Skills, Frailty, and Gear are added at promotion based on what the fiction has already established about them.

4. Let NPCs Evolve Based on the Protagonist's Actions

NPCs change in response to what happens. An alliance that's never tested and a betrayal that changes nothing are both wasted.

- **If an ally is betrayed, do they become a rival?** A former friend turned enemy adds high emotional stakes.
- **If a rival is spared, do they change their outlook?** A second chance might create an unexpected alliance, or a lingering debt.
- **If an informant is exposed, what happens?** Do they disappear, retaliate, or warn the protagonist of bigger threats?

📌 **Example: An NPC's Evolution in Action**

> At the start of the story, the protagonist knows Wren as a street hacker who sells stolen information. But after the protagonist exposes a government secret, Wren vanishes. Weeks later, they return: not as an informant, but as a leader of an underground resistance. Now, they demand something in return.

Locations, Story Hooks & Random Events

Every location should have a history, a purpose, and a tension the protagonist can act on: who controls it, what's hidden there, what happened before they arrived.

Designing Meaningful Locations

A location earns its place in the fiction by offering opportunity, danger, or mystery. If it offers none, it doesn't need detailing.

1. Locations Need Purpose

Before introducing a location, ask:

- **What role does this place serve in the fiction?** A hub, a battleground, a mystery to be solved, decide before you describe it.
- **What makes it unique?** Culture, history, or a natural phenomenon that couldn't belong anywhere else.
- **What tension exists here?** Factions vying for control, laws being broken, a past event still casting a shadow.

📌 **Example: A Location with Purpose**

> *The Hollow Monastery* – A once-sacred temple now buried under layers of ash from an ancient disaster. The faithful still make pilgrimages here, but something **lives beneath the ruins**, something that **remembers the past** and whispers in the wind.

2. What Makes a Location Unique?

A location's defining traits are what separate it from generic scenery:

- **Culture & Daily Life** – What do people here believe? How do they survive?
- **Hidden Secrets** – What do outsiders not know? What's being covered up?

- **Dangers & Obstacles** – Is the environment itself a threat? Are there factions or creatures that make this place dangerous?
- **Shifting Territories** – Is this a contested zone? Are old powers losing control, and new ones rising?

📌 **Example: A Unique Location in Action**

The Smog Market – A black-market bazaar held deep within a labyrinth of old factories. The air is thick with toxic fumes, forcing traders to wear filtration masks, and deals are sealed with ink-stamped contracts burned immediately after signing. The merchant guild enforces its own brutal laws here; violators disappear, their masks left hanging as warnings.

3. Locations Aren't Just Physical Spaces

Not every location has to be a city, temple, or battlefield:

- **A State of Mind** – A shared hallucination, a dreamscape where reality bends.
- **An Institution** – A secret society, a corporation, a faith that spans continents.
- **A Shifting Landscape** – A battlefield that changes ownership, a planet that is literally crumbling, a moving fortress.

📌 **Example: Non-Traditional Locations**

The Choir of Rust *(Institution)* – A corporation, but also a belief system: a decentralized AI-worshipping cult where members sacrifice their human memories to join the "singing data." The protagonist doesn't have to enter a

building to visit this place; being noticed by them is enough.

The Dreaming Wound *(State of Mind)* – A shared hallucination that spreads between survivors of the same disaster. Those who enter it see the same burning city, the same faces. Whether the wound is a trauma echo or something that remembers being real, no one agrees. The protagonist doesn't travel here; they fall asleep in the wrong place.

The Contested Shelf *(Shifting Landscape)* – A stretch of territory that changes hands between three factions every few weeks, too valuable to abandon, too dangerous to hold. Every return visit means different flags on the gates, different rules, different prices for the same information. Reputation here resets on a schedule.

Creating Story Hooks

Build locations around unanswered questions instead of a linear narrative; a question forces investigation, a plot just gets followed.

1. Use Questions to Drive Storytelling

Before placing the protagonist in a location, ask:

- **Who controls this place, and what do they want?**
- **What is forbidden or hidden here?**
- **What rumors or half-truths circulate about this place?**
- **What happened here before the protagonist arrived?**

📌 Example: A Location That Raises Questions

The Ivory Spire stands in the middle of the wasteland, untouched by time. No door, no entrance: just smooth

white stone stretching into the sky. A caravan once tried to camp at its base, but by morning, their footprints were gone, as if they'd never been there at all.

2. What Happens When the Protagonist Intervenes?

A location should change once the protagonist interacts with it:

- **What happens when a secret is revealed?** Does the protagonist gain allies, or are they marked for death?
- **What forces push back?** If a faction's power is threatened, how do they retaliate?
- **What changes permanently?** A settlement that was once thriving might collapse because of a single event. A wasteland might bloom if an ancient mechanism is activated.

📌 **Example: A Living Location**

In the underground tunnels of the drowned city, a hidden enclave thrives. They live off old-world technology, sealed away from the surface. But when the protagonist opens their airlocks for the first time in decades, the outside world sees a new target: fresh resources, fresh prey. The city isn't hidden anymore.

World Events

A setting shifts in response to time, power struggles, and the protagonist's actions, or it isn't really alive.

The *Loner* 4th Edition core rules include a **Living World** procedure: a post-adventure checklist for updating NPC and faction relationship tags, revising location tags, and noting what's still unresolved. Use that as your tracking baseline.

This section is about building the setting depth those tags will draw on, and generating the events worth tracking.

1. Make the World React

Some changes should happen whether or not the protagonist is there to see them.

- **Factions gain or lose influence.** A rebellion gains traction. A city falls to a new ruler.
- **Environmental changes reshape landscapes.** A volcanic eruption destroys an island. A centuries-old glacier melts.
- **Unexpected discoveries rewrite history.** A long-lost artifact surfaces and the balance of power shifts with it.

📌 Example: A Shifting World

> The great war has ended, but the power vacuum left behind is unstable. Just because the fighting stopped doesn't mean the world is at peace. Gangs rise from the ruins, warlords carve out new empires. Every time the protagonist returns to a familiar place, it has changed.

2. Introduce Random Events to Keep Things Unpredictable

Not everything needs to be planned; some of the best moments come from a disruption you didn't see coming. Roll for:

- **New conflicts** (*A new faction appears, challenging the existing order.*)
- **Environmental shifts** (*An earthquake reveals something buried beneath the city.*)
- **Personal threats** (*Someone from the protagonist's past resurfaces, seeking revenge, help, or something worse.*)

📌 **Example: A Random Event in Action**

> The protagonist is planning a quiet infiltration, but then the **entire city goes dark**. Communications fail. The power grid shuts down. No one knows why, but suddenly, everyone is scrambling to react. The mission just changed.

Adapting an Existing Setting

Adapt an existing setting by capturing its essence, not translating its rules. Every encounter, conflict, and revelation has to work without a party of adventurers standing behind the protagonist.

Whether you're starting from a published RPG, a favorite fictional universe, or your own creation, the approach is the same: distill the core themes, express them through tags, and reshape the challenges for a solo protagonist.

Guidelines for adapting settings

Step 1: Identify the Core Themes

Every setting has a heart: the themes that decide what kinds of stories belong in it. Strip away the surface details and ask:

- **What is this world really about?** Survival in a brutal wasteland, rebellion against an oppressive force, or unraveling cosmic mysteries, name the thing underneath the plot.
- **What kind of stories naturally emerge here?** Explorers, rebels, investigators, discovery, revenge, heroism, whichever pair fits is what the setting is actually generating.
- **How do characters interact with their environment and society?** Rigid social structures, a lawless frontier, a decaying empire on the edge of collapse, each produces a different protagonist.

A setting about lost knowledge and exploration produces different challenges than one about power struggles and espionage. Naming the theme is what tells you which.

📌 **Example: Identifying Themes**

> The world of "Dying Suns" is a collapsing interstellar empire, where ancient technology is failing and forgotten knowledge is worth more than gold. At its heart, this is a setting about **entropy, lost civilizations, and the cost of knowledge.** Stories here are often about salvaging what little remains, or fighting to preserve something before it's too late.

Step 2: Convert Key Elements into Tags

Instead of trying to convert **rules, stat blocks, or mechanics**, focus on breaking the setting down into **narrative-driven elements**. Tags in *Loner* are **flexible descriptors** that define **factions, locations, and conflicts** without getting bogged down in excessive mechanics.

- **Factions should have clear motives.** Instead of listing hierarchy and ranks, describe them with **tags** that define their behavior.
- **Locations should have defining traits.** Describe a place not just by what it looks like, but by how it **affects the protagonist**.
- **Conflicts should be broken into manageable story elements.** What is the protagonist up against? How does it shape the world around them?

📌 **Example: Converting Setting Elements to Tags**

The Bleeding Spire (Location)

- *Ruins of an ancient war machine, now repurposed as a city.*
- *Walls whisper with forgotten code.*
- *Controlled by warring scavenger factions.*

The Silent Choir (Faction)

- *Religious fanatics who believe silence is sacred.*
- *Mark enemies by removing their names from history.*
- *Only communicate through symbols and gestures.*

The Veil War (Conflict)

- *A shadow war between two factions, neither acknowledging the other exists.*
- *Most people caught in the middle don't know who is fighting or why.*
- *The protagonist may already be involved, without realizing it.*

Step 3: Adjust for Solo Play

Most published settings assume group dynamics: parties, crews, squads. A *Loner* protagonist is alone, so some elements need adjusting.

1. Make Challenges Work for a Lone Protagonist

- Drop the party-based tactics. Individual ingenuity, stealth, and problem-solving carry the challenge instead of team-based combat.
- Compensate with tools, allies, or strategic advantages. Where a rogue would unlock the door, the protagonist has a hacker's toolkit, or an informant with the bypass codes.

📌 **Example: Adjusting Challenges**

> Instead of a dungeon requiring multiple adventurers to solve its puzzles, a Loner adaptation could make the dungeon slowly collapse, forcing the protagonist to choose which paths to take before they're lost forever.

2. Make the World React to the Protagonist

A lone protagonist can't share the consequences of an action with a party; every one lands on them directly.

- **What happens when the protagonist changes something major?** A dead corrupt official leaves a vacancy. An exposed truth gets someone trying to silence them.
- **What factions take notice?** With no one else to blame, the protagonist becomes the target for whoever wants to control or eliminate them.

📌 **Example: A Reactive World**

> The protagonist exposes a corrupt magistrate's ledger, intending to give it to a local faction. But the ledger names three other factions as silent partners. Within a week, all three are hunting the protagonist. A local problem has become a city-wide one, and none of the parties involved share the same goal.

3. Shift the Focus to Personal Stakes

Party-based games get emotional depth from the companions. Solo play has to find it within the protagonist or in the NPCs who keep recurring.

- **Give the protagonist personal conflicts.** A past they're running from, a secret they don't want uncovered.
- **Make enemies personal.** One antagonist with a history against the protagonist hits harder than a faceless organization ever will.
- **Let NPC relationships evolve.** Can this ally actually be trusted? What agenda are they not mentioning?

📌 **Example: Personal Stakes in Solo Play**

In a traditional setting, a rebellion might be a sprawling factional war. In a Loner adaptation, the protagonist is a former revolutionary, hunted by their own allies after refusing to follow orders. Now the rebellion isn't just a cause: it's a ghost of their past, one that won't let them go.

Genre Adaptation Matrix

This matrix breaks down common genres and setting types, offering guidance on how to translate their mechanics,

themes, and challenges into *Loner*'s tag-based, emergent narrative system.

Genre	Core Themes	Protagonist's Role	Key Challenges	Adapting for *Loner*
High Fantasy	Heroism, destiny, magic, ancient evils	A chosen hero, a wandering adventurer, or an exile seeking redemption	Quests, mythical creatures, political intrigue, forbidden knowledge	Focus on a personal story rather than a party-based quest. Magic should be unpredictable, ancient secrets should emerge through play, and the world should react dynamically to the protagonist's choices.
Cyberpunk	Oppression, rebellion, corporate control, transhu-	A hacker, a rogue AI, a fixer caught between factions	Information control, megacorp enforcers, underground movements, technological decay	Make cybernetics and hacking narrative-driven rather than mechanical. Factions should act as shifting forces. The protagonist's every action should ripple through the setting.

Genre	Core Themes	Protagonist's Role	Key Challenges	Adapting for *Loner*
	manism			
Post-Apocalyptic	Survival, scarcity, lawlessness, rebuilding society	A scavenger, a survivor, a warlord, or a wanderer with a purpose	Hostile environments, dwindling resources, raiders, unknown threats	Resource management can be simplified through descriptive tags (*Well-Stocked*, *Low on Ammo*). The world should feel **hostile yet reactive**; even if the protagonist is alone, their choices shape what remains of society.
Cosmic Horror	The unknowable, fragile sanity, existential dread	A scholar, investigator, cultist-turned-traitor, or lone survivor	Eldritch forces, unreliable knowledge, conspiracies, unavoidable doom	Replace "sanity mechanics" with evolving **character tags** (e.g., *Fractured Mind*). The protagonist should slowly uncover horrific truths rather than instantly understanding them.
Noir/Detective	Corruption, moral ambigu-	A private investigator, a dis-	Murders, betrayals, conspiracies,	Instead of rigid investigation mechanics, let clues emerge organically through *Loner's* Oracle. NPC motivations should

Genre	Core Themes	Protagonist's Role	Key Challenges	Adapting for *Loner*
	ity, personal	graced cop, a criminal with a conscience	moral dilemmas	shift based on the protagonist's actions.
Science Fiction (Hard Sci-Fi)	Exploration, isolation, technology, first contact	An astronaut, a rogue AI, an explorer in deep space	Alien landscapes, political struggles, survival challenges	Keep technology speculative yet fallible. The protagonist should often be forced to improvise and deal with unintended consequences.
Western	Frontier justice, survival, revenge, law vs. chaos	A lone gunfighter, a sheriff, a bounty hunter	Outlaws, territorial disputes, corrupt landowners, harsh environments	The world should be **dangerous but personal**. Reputation-based factions (*Wanted in Redstone*, *Respected by the Ranchers*) can replace rigid law mechanics.

Using the Matrix in Play

1. **Find Your Genre:** Identify the closest genre match for your setting.

2. **Adapt Core Mechanics:** Convert systemic mechanics (like magic, hacking, or sanity) into *Loner*'s **narrative-driven** tags and prompts.
3. **Keep Challenges Personal:** A lone protagonist doesn't have party support; make sure conflicts are **survivable but high-stakes**.
4. **Let the World Respond:** Factions, environments, and supernatural forces should **adapt to the protagonist's actions**, rather than remaining static.

Adapting Large RPG Campaigns into Loner

Most RPG campaigns are built for groups: shared objectives, party-based encounters, a GM steering the plot. Adapting one means restructuring its key components for a single protagonist and an emergent story rather than a predefined path.

Step 1: Strip the Campaign Down to Its Core

Most campaigns carry complexity solo play doesn't need. Identify:

- **The Primary Conflict** – What drives the story forward? (E.g., "A rebellion is forming against a tyrant")
- **Key NPCs** – Who is central to the narrative? Strip away minor side characters unless they serve a purpose.
- **Essential Locations** – Instead of tracking every town or dungeon, focus on **landmarks that shape the protagonist's path**.
- **Major Twists** – If the campaign has multiple branching paths, focus on **one story arc**.

📌 **Example: Stripping Down a Classic Fantasy Campaign**

- Original: *A kingdom on the brink of war, multiple factions vying for power, a prophecy involving a chosen one, and a sprawling world map with 30+ locations.*
- Loner Adaptation: *The protagonist is a disgraced knight exiled after uncovering a conspiracy. The war still looms, but now it's personal: the protagonist must decide whether to fight for redemption or let the kingdom collapse.*

Step 2: Reframe Party-Based Challenges

Many campaigns assume a diverse group of heroes:

- Combat designed for multiple players working together.
- Puzzles that require specialized skills split across the party.
- Social interactions that rely on multiple perspectives in the room.

Converting Party Encounters for Solo Play

Group Encounter Type	Solo Adaptation
A battle against multiple foes	Give the protagonist environmental advantages, allow stealth-based approaches, or use the *Advantage/Disadvantage* system to keep fights winnable.
A trap requiring teamwork	Change the challenge into a **moral choice** (*You can disable the trap, but it will alert nearby enemies*).
A social encounter that assumes di-	The protagonist **must leverage existing relationships**; NPC allies become more crucial.

Group Encounter Type	Solo Adaptation
verse party skills	
Puzzles that require multiple skill checks	Make puzzle-solving **narrative-based** rather than mechanical (*Does the protagonist recognize this ancient symbol?*).

📌 **Example: Reworking a Party-Based Dungeon**

- Original: *A dungeon with four puzzles, requiring strength, agility, arcane knowledge, and a rogue's finesse to complete.*
- Loner Adaptation: *The protagonist faces a series of **choices** rather than a skill-gated path. They can force open the vault at a cost, decipher its runes with knowledge gained earlier, or manipulate an NPC into unlocking it.*

Step 3: Let the Campaign Evolve Through Play

A traditional RPG has a GM adjusting the game in response to players. In *Loner*, the Oracle and D66 tables take over that role.

- **Use the Oracle to introduce twists.** If a campaign moment feels predictable, ask:
  - *Is there an unexpected danger here?*
  - *Has an unseen force been tracking the protagonist?*
  - *Does an NPC reveal something new?*

- **Modify Campaign Goals as Needed.** If a campaign is built around a **party's collective decision-making**, the solo protagonist should have **shifting personal goals**.
  - If the original goal was *defeat the necromancer*, the *Loner* version might be **"Find the truth about the necromancer's origins"**, allowing for **a more investigative, character-driven approach**.

📌 **Example: Shifting a War Campaign for Solo Play**

- Original: *A sprawling war campaign where players pick a side and fight battles across multiple cities.*
- Loner Adaptation: *The protagonist is a rogue operative, navigating the war from the shadows, smuggling messages, sabotaging key locations, and uncovering hidden truths about the war's origins.*

Step 4: Replace Side Quests with Personal Story Arcs

Side quests in group campaigns exist to keep multiple players engaged. Replace them with personal stakes instead:

Group Side Quest	Solo Version
Retrieve an artifact for an NPC	The artifact **has a personal connection to the protagonist**, forcing a dilemma (keep it or return it?).
Escort a merchant through a dangerous region	The merchant is an **old rival**, and they know something about the protagonist's past.
Infiltrate a crime syndicate for intelligence	The protagonist's **own survival depends on convinc-**

Group Side Quest	Solo Version
	ing the syndicate they belong.

The tools above give you the structural pieces of an adapted campaign. The next chapter covers D66 random tables: the randomness engine that stands in for a GM's improvisation, keeping adapted material alive and unpredictable in play.

Crafting D66 Random Tables

> **Optional module.** This chapter covers techniques for creating custom D66 random tables. Use it when you want to build setting-specific tools for encounters, twists, and worldbuilding.

The D66 table is one of *Loner*'s most useful tools: a compact engine of surprise for setting creation, encounters, and twists, built to spark an idea when you're stuck rather than hand you a finished answer.

This chapter covers designing custom D66 tables that fit your own setting.

What is a D66 Table?

A D66 table is a **two-dice randomizer** that generates results between **11 and 66** (not 2–12, like a standard 2d6 roll). Each die is read separately, forming a two-digit number:

- Rolling a **1** on the first die and a **4** on the second gives **14**.
- Rolling a **5** on the first die and a **6** on the second gives **56**.

This results in **36 unique entries**, making D66 tables a compact but deep tool for solo play.

Why Use a D66 Table?

- **Unexpected Inspiration**: Randomness breaks whatever predictable pattern you'd have defaulted to.
- **Minimal Setup, Maximum Impact**: One table, 36 entries, dozens of usable prompts.
- **Reusability**: A well-built table survives more than one session.

Using D66 Tables in Play

D66 tables work alongside the Oracle, not instead of it. The Oracle answers the core question: did it happen, and at what cost? A D66 table adds texture to the interpretation: who showed up, what the location looks like, what complication the twist brings. Roll the Oracle first. When the result needs more than a yes or no to narrate, that's when a table earns its roll. Some tables, like encounter generators, can also replace a framing question when you need a scene prompt rather than a binary answer, but that use should be deliberate, not the default.

Step 1: Defining the Purpose of Your Table

Before you start filling in entries, ask yourself:

- **What problem does this table solve?**
  - Does it generate **setting details**, **encounters**, or **story twists**?
  - Does it introduce **worldbuilding elements** (like rumors, NPCs, or conflicts)?
- **How often will you roll on it?**
  - Is this a one-time setup table (like a world generator)?
  - Is it a recurring tool (like a random event table)?
- **What kind of tone should it set?**
  - Does it introduce danger, intrigue, humor, or the surreal?
  - Should it fit a specific genre or setting?

Once you define these parameters, you can move on to crafting the entries.

Step 2: Structuring the Table for Maximum Usefulness

A D66 table needs to balance variety, thematic focus, and usability.

Categorizing the Results

- If your table is broad, divide results into categories for clarity.
- For example, in an **"Unexpected Events"** table, the first digit might represent **general types of events**, and the second digit **specific variations** within that category:
  - **1X** = Weather effects
  - **2X** = Encounters
  - **3X** = Internal conflicts
  - **4X** = Mystical occurrences
  - **5X** = Structural failures
  - **6X** = Outside interference

Ensuring a Mix of Outcomes

A table that mixes low-impact results, mid-tier complications, and game-changing ones lets the Oracle shape the fiction instead of railroading it:

- **Mundane but flavorful results** (e.g., "A trader offers a rare, but oddly specific, item").
- **Useful resources or advantages** (e.g., "You find an unexpected shortcut").
- **New obstacles or tensions** (e.g., "Your next action is interrupted by a faction agent").
- **Big story twists** (e.g., "An NPC reveals a secret that changes everything").

Step 3: Writing the Entries

A good entry is concise, evocative, and open-ended. An overly specific result leaves no room for interpretation; a prompt adapts to whatever situation it lands in.

Tips for Writing Effective Entries

- **Keep them short** (1–2 sentences max)
- **Use evocative language** that suggests multiple interpretations
- **Leave space for you to decide**

📌 **Example: An Entry**

> A noble offers you aid but demands a costly favor in return.

This doesn't dictate how the noble behaves or what the favor is, letting you interpret based on the setting and previous story events.

Creating a Balanced Spread of Entries

A good D66 table isn't all highs or all lows. Distribute entries across intensities:

1. **Neutral worldbuilding details (low stakes, useful for flavor).**
   - "A statue here is missing its head. No one remembers why."
2. **Mild complications (things that add flavor but aren't immediate threats).**
   - "Someone in town claims they saw you do something you didn't do."
3. **Active problems (things you must respond to).**
   - "You are being followed. The follower is not making an effort to hide."
4. **Major shifts (introducing drastic change to the game world).**
   - "An event forces a faction leader into exile, leaving a power vacuum."

Step 4: Testing and Refining the Table

Roll on the drafted table multiple times and check whether the results fit naturally, avoid redundancy, and inspire rather than frustrate.

- **Are any results too vague or confusing?**
- **Do any results feel redundant?**
- **Do extreme results appear too often?** Rebalance if so.

Replace any entry that doesn't earn its slot.

Step 5: Making Your D66 Tables Fit Your Setting

D66 tables should be tailored to the **tone and needs of your world**. The easiest way to make a table feel genre-specific is to write three entries first: one low-stakes, one active compli-

cation, one major shift. If all three produce the right tone, fill the remaining 33 entries in the same register.

Same table slot, different genres

The following shows a single D66 result (23: a suspicious group) rewritten for two different settings:

Setting	Entry 23
Cyberpunk	A corporate security sweep closes the district. The protagonist has one hour before the checkpoints seal.
Cosmic Horror	A fisherman at the docks has been speaking in a language no one recognizes for three days. He doesn't know he's doing it.

The slot type (suspicious group, mid-stakes) is the same. The genre does the rest.

For recurring-use tables (random events, faction reactions), favor open-ended prompts. For setup tables used once (world generator, opening scene), more specific entries work better because the table won't be rolled again.

Common table types by setting need:

- **Random Encounters**: Who does the protagonist run into, and what do they want? Best kept open-ended so results work across different phases of the story.
- **Story Twists**: What unexpected event changes the protagonist's course? These can be more specific, since a given twist may only fire once.

- **Unusual Items** (scavenger/salvage settings): What does the protagonist find? Mix mundane value with objects that raise questions.
- **Faction Reactions**: How do groups respond to the protagonist's last action? Calibrate to the current tension level in the setting.

Step 6: Expanding and Combining Tables

Once you've built a few D66 tables, you can:

- **Link them together**: Rolling on one table can lead to another (e.g., rolling a faction encounter can trigger a separate reaction table).
- **Modify them with situation-based rules**: Have different interpretations based on where you are (e.g., the same "Lost Traveler" encounter means different things in a desert versus a haunted ruin).
- **Build specialized versions**: Create smaller, setting-specific tables that add depth, like "Rumors in the Tavern" or "Corporate Secrets."

Appendix: How to Write D66 Tables

Optional module. Use these templates as starting points for your own D66 tables.

Use the following as starting templates. Each entry below is written to serve a distinct narrative function, not to fill a slot arbitrarily; adapt the guidance to your setting rather than using the wording as-is.

D66 Random Encounter Table Template

Use this table to generate encounters with a mix of tension, opportunity, and intrigue.

D66	Guidance for Entry
11	**A routine or mundane encounter that still adds flavor.** Example: A traveler, a merchant, or a group of locals engaged in their daily lives.
12	**An NPC who presents an unusual opportunity.** Example: Someone with information, a map, or a tempting offer.
13	**An NPC with unclear motives.** Example: A beggar, a spy, or someone pretending to be lost. What do they *really* want?
14	**Someone is tracking the protagonist without approaching.** Example: The same face appears in different locations. Are they surveillance, a guardian, or

D66	Guidance for Entry
	waiting for the right moment?
15	**A figure of authority or power.** Example: A guard, noble, or crime boss who may be an obstacle or ally.
16	**A character tied to the protagonist's past.** Example: A former ally, rival, or mentor with a personal stake in their actions.
21	**A non-human entity.** Example: A stray animal, a malfunctioning drone, or a supernatural presence.
22	**A character in distress.** Example: Someone in immediate danger; what happened, and should the protagonist intervene?
23	**A suspicious group.** Example: Bandits, cultists, corporate agents. What are they up to?
24	**A faction representative.** Example: A recruiter, emissary, or rival operative sent to make contact.
25	**A potential informant.** Example: Someone who

D66	Guidance for Entry
	knows something but may not be eager to share.
26	**A harmless situation that could escalate.** Example: A local argument, a street performance, or a simple misunderstanding.
31	**A character seeking revenge.** Example: Someone who believes the protagonist wronged them, rightly or wrongly.
32	**An NPC offering a shortcut or tool.** Example: A smuggler, a hacker, or a scholar with knowledge that can change the protagonist's course.
33	**A detail from the world's past intrudes on the present.** Example: Someone names a place, a faction, or a figure that shouldn't still exist. Why do they know that name?
34	**A minor inconvenience or test.** Example: Pickpockets, a lost item, or someone blocking the protagonist's way.

D66	Guidance for Entry
35	**A direct challenge.** Example: A rival demands a duel, an official makes an accusation, or a gang issues a threat.
36	**A hidden trap.** Example: The protagonist is lured somewhere under false pretenses. Why?
41	**A peaceful interaction that sets up something bigger.** Example: A storyteller, an artist, or a monk who shares something thought-provoking.
42	**A guide or local expert.** Example: Someone who knows the area well but has their own agenda.
43	**A character with unfinished business.** Example: A bounty hunter looking for someone, a runaway hiding from something.
44	**An adversary disguised as a friend.** Example: Someone pretending to help the protagonist while working against them.

D66	Guidance for Entry
45	**A rumor in motion.** Example: A heated discussion about a recent event, a political crisis, or a monster sighting.
46	**A strange coincidence.** Example: Someone with information that is unexpectedly relevant to the protagonist's goals.
51	**A staged commotion is designed to move the protagonist.** Example: A fight, a cry for help, or a street collapse; the event is real enough, but its timing is not accidental.
52	**An encounter that foreshadows a major event.** Example: Someone drops an ominous warning, a newspaper hints at a coming disaster.
53	**An urgent message.** Example: A courier or whisper network member delivers news that affects the protagonist.
54	**A supernatural occurrence.** Example: A ghost, an inexplicable omen, or an artifact that reacts strangely.

D66	Guidance for Entry
55	**A deal that seems too good to be true.** Example: A merchant, a politician, or an outlaw offers something valuable at a suspiciously low cost.
56	**A crisis requiring immediate attention.** Example: A fire, an accident, or a sudden attack. What just changed?
61	**An old friend or mentor.** Example: Someone who knew the protagonist before everything changed. What do they want now?
62	**A betrayal in progress.** Example: The protagonist overhears or stumbles upon an act of treachery.
63	**The protagonist learns something about themselves they didn't expect.** Example: A stranger's reaction, a document, or a passing remark reframes what the protagonist thought they understood about their own past.
64	**An invitation to something larger.** Example: A secret

D66	Guidance for Entry
	meeting, a private auction, or a cult initiation.
65	**A game-changing revelation.** Example: A hidden truth about the protagonist's past, a long-buried conspiracy, or a prophecy fulfilled.
66	**An event that forces the protagonist to act.** Example: A personal rival escalates matters, a faction declares war, or an entire location is thrown into chaos.

D66 Story Twist Table Template

Use this to generate unexpected narrative developments.

This table can also stand in for the core Twist Table: when the Twist Counter triggers, roll here instead of the core 2d6 Subject and Action columns for a setting-specific result. Decide which table serves a given campaign before play starts, and stick with it; switching mid-story makes Twists feel arbitrary rather than inevitable.

D66	Guidance for Entry
11	**A faction suddenly changes its stance.** Example: An ally withdraws support, or an enemy extends an offer of peace.

D66	Guidance for Entry
12	**A natural or cosmic force intervenes.** Example: A storm, an earthquake, or an eclipse disrupts the current situation.
13	**An NPC makes a surprising confession.** Example: They reveal hidden knowledge, admit guilt, or claim to be an imposter.
14	**A location transforms unexpectedly.** Example: A hidden chamber is discovered, a portal activates, or a building collapses.
15	**A past mistake resurfaces.** Example: An old debt is called in, or someone the protagonist wronged seeks revenge.
16	**A mysterious artifact changes hands.** Example: A relic is stolen, found, or becomes sentient.
21	**A familiar face is not what they seemed.** Example: An ally is actually a double agent, or an enemy had good intentions all along.

D66	Guidance for Entry
22	**A piece of technology or magic malfunctions.** Example: A power source destabilizes, a device gains a mind of its own.
23	**A rumor turns out to be a lie, or the truth.** Example: A well-known legend is revealed to be real, or a trusted fact is debunked.
24	**A major NPC disappears.** Example: A faction leader vanishes, a mentor leaves without explanation.
25	**A conflict escalates beyond expectation.** Example: A minor skirmish turns into a war, or a local dispute sparks rebellion.
26	**Something once thought lost returns.** Example: A presumed-dead character resurfaces, or an extinct species is rediscovered.
31	**The protagonist's goal is revealed to be misdirected.** Example: The target was never the real threat, or the mission was a distraction.

D66	Guidance for Entry
32	**A hidden alliance comes to light.** Example: Two factions that seemed opposed have been coordinating all along.
33	**The rules of the world change.** Example: A power that was reliable stops working, or a new force makes old strategies obsolete.
34	**An unexpected betrayal within a trusted group.** Example: Someone close turns on the protagonist, or an internal faction splinters.
35	**A revelation reframes everything prior.** Example: A fact the protagonist accepted as true is exposed as a fabrication.
36	**A new power enters the scene.** Example: A third faction appears, an ancient entity wakes, or an outside force arrives with its own agenda.
41	**The protagonist is blamed for something they didn't do.** Example: A disaster occurs and all evidence points toward them.

D66	Guidance for Entry
42	**A resource the protagonist depended on is cut off.** Example: An ally withdraws, a supply route closes, or crucial information is destroyed.
43	**The protagonist's identity or cover is compromised.** Example: Someone who shouldn't know who they are now does.
44	**The stakes escalate without warning.** Example: What was a personal conflict is suddenly a matter of regional or global consequence.
45	**A ticking clock appears.** Example: A deadline is imposed by an external force, and failure has permanent consequences.
46	**An NPC makes a desperate and irreversible choice.** Example: They sacrifice something to protect the protagonist, or destroy something to stop them.
51	**The environment becomes hostile.** Example: The loca-

D66	Guidance for Entry
	tion itself is now dangerous, whether through weather, structural failure, or something worse.
52	**The protagonist's last safe option disappears.** Example: The fallback plan fails, the backup contact goes silent, or the escape route is already watched.
53	**Someone the protagonist thought was an enemy offers help.** Example: A rival extends an unexpected hand, with or without stated conditions.
54	**The protagonist is given an impossible choice.** Example: Two equally important things are at risk and only one can be saved.
55	**A secret the protagonist was keeping is exposed.** Example: Something they hid comes into the open at the worst possible moment.
56	**A chain of consequences catches up all at once.** Example: Several earlier decisions collide, producing a

D66	Guidance for Entry
	situation no single choice caused.
61	**A symbol or ritual gains unexpected power.** Example: Something treated as meaningless becomes critically important.
62	**The protagonist receives an urgent message from the past.** Example: Old notes, a recording, or a message written before everything changed arrives now.
63	**A secondary character is forced to the center.** Example: A background NPC becomes central to the conflict, by choice or circumstance.
64	**The world reacts to the protagonist's reputation.** Example: Their actions have spread, and strangers now respond to them as a known quantity.
65	**An alliance that seemed stable collapses.** Example: A group the protagonist relied on fractures, disbands,

D66	Guidance for Entry
	or turns against one another.
66	**A major setback arrives at the worst possible moment.** Example: Reinforcements arrive for the opposition just as the protagonist commits to their plan, raising the cost of success dramatically.

Appendix: Remixing D66 Tables for Different Genres

> **Optional module.** Use these techniques to adapt existing D66 tables to new settings without building from scratch.

Creating new D66 tables from scratch can be a fun but time-consuming process. Instead of reinventing the wheel, one of the easiest ways to generate **setting-specific tables** is by **remixing** existing ones. This means adjusting **tone,**

language, and context to fit a different genre while keeping the structure intact.

Step 1: Identify the Core Function of the Table

Before modifying an existing table, ask:

1. **What does this table generate?** (Encounters, twists, locations, mysteries, etc.)
2. **What role does it play in the game?** (Is it meant to challenge, inspire, or surprise?)
3. **Does the structure still work?** (Does every result make sense in the new context?)

Step 2: Adjust the Language to Match the Genre

Different settings need different tones and terminology, but the same table structure can feel radically different with just a few word swaps.

Example: A "Mysterious Encounter" Table Across Three Genres

The following is a simplified D6 comparison to illustrate the remix principle. A full table would use the D66 format with 36 entries.

D6	Fantasy	Cyberpunk	Post-Apocalyptic
1	A hooded traveler offers a cryptic warning.	A masked hacker sends you an encrypted message.	A nomad scrawls a message in the dust before vanishing.
2	A knight challenges you to a duel.	A corporate enforcer demands a meeting.	A warlord's lieutenant claims you owe a debt.

D6	Fantasy	Cyberpunk	Post-Apocalyptic
3	A merchant has an item that shouldn't exist.	A black-market dealer offers rare tech.	A scavenger tries to sell you something "cursed."
4	An old friend has changed allegiances.	A former ally now works for a rival corp.	A past companion is now the leader of a raider gang.
5	A celestial event is considered an omen.	A solar flare disrupts all tech.	A strange storm sweeps through, carrying whispers.
6	A strange animal follows you and speaks in dreams.	A synthetic pet contains encrypted memories.	A mutated creature mimics your voice at night.

Takeaways from This Remix

- The core structure stays identical.
- Tone and terminology shift to fit the setting.
- The entry's function is the same; its meaning in context isn't.

Step 3: Modify the Scale and Scope

Not all genres operate at the same scale. Some need larger-than-life conflicts; others work best kept personal.

- **Epic Fantasy vs. Gritty Noir**
  - In fantasy, a D66 "Big Event" table might include **godly interventions** or **kingdom-wide conspiracies**.
  - In noir, the same table would focus on **criminal power struggles**, **personal betrayals**, and **hidden truths**.

- **Hard Sci-Fi vs. Pulp Sci-Fi**
  - In a *hard sci-fi* setting, a D66 "Travel Complications" table might include **realistic malfunctions, radiation storms, and AI failures**.
  - In a *pulp sci-fi* setting, the same table could include **alien ruins, space pirates, and cosmic horrors**.

Practical Application

Take an existing table and adjust entries **one at a time** by asking:

1. Does this result fit **the scale of my world**?
2. Should I **expand or shrink** the scope to match the genre?
3. Can I replace elements **without changing the table's function**?

Step 4: Swap Out Unfitting Entries

Some entries won't work in a new genre at all. Swap them for something that serves the same narrative role in a way that fits the setting, rather than forcing the original to work.

Example: Converting a "Mystical Omens" Table for Different Genres

The **original** fantasy-focused table includes:

- **A comet streaks across the sky, foretelling great change.**
- **A flock of crows gathers in unnatural numbers.**
- **An ancient rune glows for the first time in centuries.**

For a **Cyberpunk setting**, we could swap these for:

- **A satellite burns up on reentry, throwing the city into panic.**
- **Drone surveillance intensifies, seemingly watching for something specific.**

- **A glitch in the city's holographic billboards reveals a hidden message.**

For a **Post-Apocalyptic setting**, they could be changed to:

- **A falling star crashes into the wasteland, setting off rumors of treasure.**
- **A swarm of rats flees in a single direction. What are they running from?**
- **A bunker door unlocks after decades of being sealed.**

In each case, the role of the result stays the same, a mysterious event that shakes things up, while the flavor shifts completely.

Step 5: Balance High, Medium, and Low-Impact Results

Every D66 table needs a mix:

- **Mild flavor entries** (small world details, non-critical interactions).
- **Mid-level complications** (things the protagonist must respond to).
- **Major game-changing moments** (shifts in the world, serious dangers, huge opportunities).

When remixing a table from another genre, keep each intensity level balanced, or the results end up too chaotic or too mild.

Example: Adapting a "Faction Reaction" Table for Different Genres

A **Faction Reaction Table** for a medieval fantasy setting might include:

- **Minor (Low Impact)**: A noble sends a polite invitation for a meeting.

- **Mid-Level (Requires Response)**: A guild places restrictions on your access to city resources.
- **Major (Big Consequences)**: A war declaration puts you on one side or the other.

For a **dystopian cyberpunk setting**, the same progression could become:

- **Minor**: A megacorp offers a one-time deal with unknown strings attached.
- **Mid-Level**: A hacker group disrupts city-wide power, affecting your plans.
- **Major**: A government agency marks you as a national security threat.

Step 6: When to Keep Entries Vague vs. Specific

Some genres thrive on open-ended prompts; others benefit from detailed results.

- **Open-Ended Prompts (Good for Mystery & Exploration)**
  - "A stranger approaches with an urgent warning" → Who are they? What's the warning about?
  - "A faction is mobilizing for an unknown reason" → What caused this? How does it affect the protagonist?
- **Detailed Results (Good for High-Stakes, Fast-Paced Genres)**
  - "A bounty of 500,000 credits has been placed on your head by the Black Sun Syndicate."
  - "A rogue AI is rewriting security protocols at the city's central data hub."

When remixing a table, decide whether the new genre benefits more from vagueness or clear direction, then commit to one.

Building a Collection of Remixable Tables

Build a core set of remixable D66 tables you can adjust on the fly, instead of starting from scratch for every game.

- **Keep a "Base Structure" Version** of each table.
- **Mark adaptable elements** that can be swapped for different settings.
- **Test new versions** by rolling a few times and checking if the results make sense.

Taking Your World into Play

A worldbuilding guide is only useful once you stop reading it. The tools here are starting points: the setting you describe on paper will shift the moment the Oracle contradicts your assumptions, an NPC surprises you, or a D66 roll drops something unexpected into a scene you thought you understood.

Start with the minimum. One theme, one conflict, one protagonist, one location with an unanswered question. Roll the Oracle. See what happens. Build outward from what the fiction demands.

For the protagonist creation procedure, the core Oracle mechanic, and the Living World procedure, see the 4th Edition core rules. For the thinking behind those procedures, see the *Loner Companion*.

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Loner 4e: World Builder's Guide

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